

Chemotherapy for mesothelioma

Your doctor may offer you chemotherapy to help slow the growth of mesothelioma and control symptoms.

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Chemotherapy for mesothelioma

Chemotherapy uses anti-cancer (cytotoxic) drugs to destroy cancer cells. Cytotoxic means toxic to cells. These drugs disrupt the way cancer cells grow and divide but they also affect normal cells.

Chemotherapy for pleural mesothelioma

Your doctor may offer chemotherapy to help slow the growth of [pleural mesothelioma](#). It may also help with symptoms such as pain and breathlessness. Your doctor will tell you if chemotherapy is suitable for you.

Chemotherapy for peritoneal mesothelioma

Your doctor may offer chemotherapy to help slow the growth of [peritoneal mesothelioma](#) and control symptoms. This may be offered if immunotherapy is not suitable for you, or if you have already had immunotherapy. Your doctor will tell you if chemotherapy is right for you.

How chemotherapy is given

Chemotherapy drugs for pleural and peritoneal mesothelioma are usually given by injection into a vein (intravenously), or by a drip (infusion). Chemotherapy is usually given as a session of treatment. Each session of treatment may last between 1 and a few days. This is followed by a rest period of a few weeks. The treatment and the rest period make up a cycle of treatment. How many cycles you have will depend on:

- the [stage of the cancer](#)
- how well the cancer is responding to treatment
- the side effects of the treatment.

Chemotherapy into the abdomen

If you are having [surgery for peritoneal mesothelioma](#), your doctor may suggest having chemotherapy into the tummy (abdomen) during the surgery. This is called [HIPEC \(hyperthermic intraperitoneal chemotherapy\)](#).

Chemotherapy drugs

Chemotherapy drugs for pleural mesothelioma

The most commonly used drugs to treat pleural mesothelioma are [pemetrexed \(Alimta®\)](#) together with [carboplatin](#) or [cisplatin](#).

Chemotherapy drugs for peritoneal mesothelioma

The most commonly used drugs to treat peritoneal mesothelioma are [pemetrexed \(Alimta®\)](#) together with [cisplatin](#), or sometimes [carboplatin](#).

You usually have these drugs as an outpatient on the same day. You will then have a rest period with no chemotherapy for 20 days, before starting your next cycle of treatment.

If you have pemetrexed, you will be given vitamin B12 and folic acid. For peritoneal mesothelioma you will also be given [steroids](#). These help to reduce the side effects of treatment. You may also be given other medicines to take at home.

Other chemotherapy drugs are sometimes used for pleural and peritoneal mesothelioma. These may be given as part of a [clinical trial](#).

Side effects of chemotherapy

Chemotherapy can cause side effects. These can often be managed with drugs and usually improve after treatment has finished. Different drugs cause different side effects. Your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist will explain what to expect.

We explain some of the most common side effects of pemetrexed, cisplatin and carboplatin here, as well as some ways to reduce or control them. You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are very unlikely to get all of them.

- Risk of [infection](#)
- Bruising and bleeding
- Anaemia (low number of red blood cells)
- [Feeling sick](#)
- [Sore mouth and throat](#)

- Diarrhoea
- [Numb or tingling hands or feet \(peripheral neuropathy\)](#)
- Hearing changes.

Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any side effects.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our mesothelioma cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

An anonymous network of people affected by mesothelioma which is free to join. Share experiences, ask questions and talk to people who understand.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help